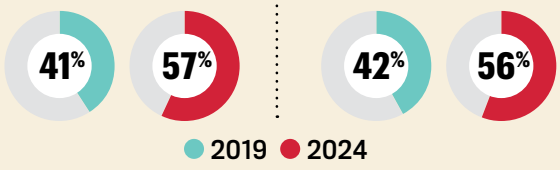
The Snack Nation

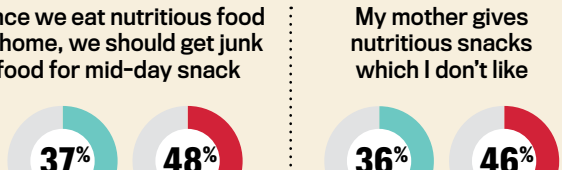
More Indians show a growing preference for fried foods and packaged snacks over nutrition



Source: TGI Consumer Analysis 2024, 50,219 respondents from urban India

Little Junk Lovers

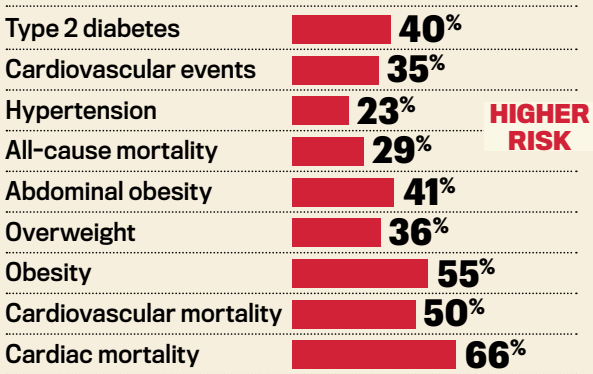
More Gen Alpha kids are choosing junk food over home-cooked meals



Source: Kantar's Kidscan survey of 2,450 kids aged 5-14 years and equal number of parents spread across 14 Indian cities

Silent Threat

The consumption of ultra-processed foods is linked to an increased risk of 32 health issues



Source: The BMJ, 2023

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

is similar to how addictive substances like nicotine or drugs work, explains Dr Ranjan.

Similarly, junk food consumption interferes with hunger-regulating hormones. After a meal, hormones like ghrelin (which signals hunger) and leptin (which signals fullness) are produced in the stomach. Ultra-processed foods contain artificial additives, high fat and sugar, which can cause leptin resistance—making it harder for the body to recognise when it is full. Meanwhile, since ghrelin remains high, a person is likely to overeat, creating a vicious cycle that leads to obesity and other hormonal imbalances, he says.

The unfortunate truth, IFPRI's Menon adds, is that the food industry, and particularly its food marketers, have understood what public health research hasn't—how individuals make food choices. They exploit this knowledge to promote, market and sell unhealthy foods. Nothing exemplifies this better than instant noodles. When launched in India, they were positioned as a convenient, affordable evening snack for mothers to prepare quickly. The brand's messaging resonated with housewives seeking a balance between convenience and the desire to make something within minutes for their children.

CRISIS OF QUALITY

As a result, says health influencer Revant Himatsingka, who goes by the handle FoodPharmer on social media, Indians are not just eating more junk food, but they are eating the worst kind. In 2019, a study published in the University of Oxford's *Obesity Reviews* found that packaged foods and drinks available in India are the least healthy among the 12 countries analysed (including the US, Australia and China) with high levels of saturated fat, sugar and salt.

In fact, the global nonprofit Access to Nutrition Initiative (ATNi) calls out major FMCG companies, including Nestlé, PepsiCo and Unilever, for selling less healthy products in low- and middle-income countries, including India, compared to what they sell in high-income countries. Its report dived into 1,901 products from 20 companies that constituted 36 per cent of the total sales (FY21) of processed food and beverage in India. However, Inoshi Sharma, executive director, Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), disputes these findings, arguing that "the ATNi report is completely wrong as the companies are not violating our regulations. For instance, if Nestle is putting sugar in the baby food in India, it is as per our norms here."

While the ATNi report didn't name the products, Himatsingka identified some of them. For instance, he alleged, Nestlé's KitKat sold in Australia contains at least 22 per cent cocoa, whereas in India, it has only 4.4 per cent. Similarly, he claimed that the classic salted variant of PepsiCo's Lay's potato chips is made with cheaper palm oil in India, which has high saturated fat, whereas in Europe and the US, it is made with sunflower oil. Nestlé India spokesperson says they apply the same principles on nutrition, health and wellness everywhere. "All our products are nutritionally balanced and adhere to the guidelines defined by the concerned authorities. The difference in formulation of products can be attributed to factors such as taste sensitivities, weather conditions and availability of raw materials." The company claims that